JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 2: Government Services & Citizen Rights

Module 9 - Elections & Democratic Participation

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Elections & Democratic Participation** — covering the Election Commission of India, Voter Registration, the Electoral Roll, the Voting Process, the Model Code of Conduct, the Importance of Voting, EVM & VVPAT basics, and Ethical Voting Practices. This module is strictly non-partisan — it explains how India's electoral system and institutions work, not who to vote for.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to understand how elections work in India and how to participate in them confidently.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Explain the structure and role of the Election Commission of India
- Register as a voter and understand the electoral roll process
- Describe the step-by-step voting process at a polling booth
- Understand the Model Code of Conduct and why it exists
- Explain how EVMs and VVPATs work, and their legal standing
- Practise ethical, informed voting as a responsible citizen

Why This Topic Matters

The Election Commission of India (ECI) manages elections for over **900 million voters** across 28 states and 8 Union Territories — making it, during Lok Sabha elections, **the largest election-conducting organisation in the world**, deploying over a million personnel. Established on **25 January 1950**, the ECI has conducted free and fair elections in India for 75 years.

> *Reality Check: Being eligible to vote and actually being registered correctly on the electoral roll are two different things — many citizens discover only on election day that a name, address, or age detail was never updated, costing them their vote for that election.*

Elections are the mechanism through which citizens exercise real power in a democracy. Understanding the process — from registration to the ballot — ensures that power is never lost to a simple, avoidable administrative gap.

Introduction

India's electoral system rests on a few interconnected foundations:

- **The Election Commission of India (ECI)** — the constitutional body conducting elections

- **The Electoral Roll** — the official list of eligible voters, which you must be correctly registered on
- **The Voting Process** — the standardised steps every voter follows at a polling booth
- **The Model Code of Conduct (MCC)** — guidelines ensuring fair conduct during the election period
- **EVMs and VVPATs** — the technology used to cast and verify votes
- **Ethical Voting Practices** — the personal responsibilities that come with the right to vote

Fundamental Concepts

The Election Commission of India at a Glance

Aspect	Detail
Established	25 January 1950 (celebrated annually as National Voters' Day)
Constitutional Basis	Article 324 of the Constitution of India
Composition	A Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and two Election Commissioners
Appointment	By the President, on the recommendation of a Selection Committee headed by the Prime Minister, including the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and a Union Minister nominated by the PM
Term	6 years, or up to age 65, whichever comes first

Key Voter Registration Forms

Form	Purpose
Form 6	New voter registration (first-time voters, or those who've moved constituencies)
Form 7	Objecting to an entry or seeking deletion from the electoral roll
Form 8	Correction of entries or address within the same constituency

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Election Commission of India (ECI)

Definition: An independent constitutional body established under Article 324, responsible for conducting free and fair elections to the offices of President, Vice-President, Parliament, and State Legislatures.

Structure: As of 2025–2026, the ECI comprises the Chief Election Commissioner and two Election Commissioners, appointed under the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023.

Why it matters: The ECI's independence from the government of the day is what allows it to enforce the Model Code of Conduct impartially and manage elections at a scale of over 900 million voters.

Part B — Voter Registration

How it works: Any Indian citizen aged 18 or above, ordinarily resident in a constituency, can register using **Form 6** on the National Voters' Service Portal (**voters.eci.gov.in**).

Process: Register/log in with mobile OTP, fill in personal details (name, date of birth, gender, relative's name, address), upload a photograph and supporting documents, and submit. A **Booth Level Officer (BLO)** may conduct field verification before your name is added.

After submission: Track your application using the reference number provided; once accepted, you can download your digital **e-EPIC** (Electors Photo Identity Card).

Part C — The Electoral Roll

Definition: The official list of all registered voters in a constituency, maintained and periodically updated by the ECI through Electoral Registration Officers.

Why it matters: Only citizens whose names appear correctly on the electoral roll for their constituency can vote there — making accurate registration essential.

Corrections: Use Form 8 for corrections (name spelling, address, photo) or Form 7 to object to or request deletion of an entry (e.g., for a deceased or relocated voter).

Part D — The Voting Process

At the polling booth, the process typically follows these steps:

1. The voter's identity is verified against the electoral roll by the first polling officer
2. The voter's finger is marked with indelible ink by the second polling officer
3. The voter signs or thumb-prints the register, and their name is crossed off the roll
4. The voter proceeds to the EVM, selects their choice, and presses the blue button
5. An LED confirms the vote, and the VVPAT machine displays a paper slip confirming the choice for a few seconds

If a voter believes the VVPAT slip doesn't match their EVM selection, they can raise this with the presiding officer for redressal under the prescribed procedure.

Part E — Model Code of Conduct (MCC)

Definition: A set of guidelines issued by the ECI governing the conduct of political parties and candidates during elections, covering meetings, processions, election manifestos, polling conduct, and general behaviour.

History: The MCC originated with the 1960 Kerala Assembly elections, was circulated nationally ahead of the 1962 Lok Sabha elections, and was applied more stringently from 1991 onward following repeated violations.

How it works: The MCC comes into force immediately upon the announcement of an election schedule and remains in effect until the process concludes, helping ensure a level playing field for all contesting parties and candidates.

Part F — The Importance of Voting

Voting is the primary mechanism through which citizens participate directly in choosing their representatives and shaping public policy. Beyond being a right, wide citizen participation strengthens the legitimacy and representativeness of elected governments at every level — from local bodies to Parliament.

Part G — EVM & VVPAT Basics

Definition: An **Electronic Voting Machine (EVM)** records votes electronically via a simple button-press system; a **Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT)** is an attached unit that prints and briefly displays a paper slip confirming the vote, without the voter retaining it.

Legal standing: Following the Supreme Court's ruling in *Subramanian Swamy v. Election Commission of India*, VVPATs became mandatory as an indispensable safeguard for free and fair elections. Subsequent rulings (including *N. Chandrababu Naidu v. Union of India*) increased random VVPAT cross-verification from 1 to 5 EVMs per assembly constituency/segment.

2024 Supreme Court Ruling: In April 2024, the Supreme Court dismissed petitions seeking 100% EVM-VVPAT cross-verification or a return to paper ballots, affirming that EVMs are "simple, secure, and user-friendly" while directing the ECI to implement additional safeguards, including sealing of symbol-loading units and provisions allowing runner-up candidates to request technical verification of EVM microcontrollers after results, at their own cost.

Part H — Ethical Voting Practices

- Vote based on your own informed judgement, free from inducement, coercion, or bribery
- Respect the secrecy of the ballot — you are never obligated to disclose who you voted for
- Verify election-related information (dates, candidate details, results) only through official ECI sources
- Report any instance of bribery, intimidation, or MCC violation to the ECI or local election authorities

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Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
ECI	Election Commission of India
CEC	Chief Election Commissioner
Electoral Roll	The official list of registered voters for a constituency
e-EPIC	The digital version of the Electors Photo Identity Card (Voter ID)
BLO	Booth Level Officer, who assists with local voter roll verification
MCC	Model Code of Conduct
EVM	Electronic Voting Machine
VVPAT	Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail

Step-by-Step Understanding

How to Register as a Voter

1. Visit voters.eci.gov.in and register/log in with mobile OTP

2. Select "New voter registration" and fill in Form 6 with your details
3. Upload your photograph and supporting identity/address/age documents
4. Submit and note your reference/application number
5. Await BLO verification if required, then track status online
6. Download your e-EPIC once your registration is accepted

How Voting Happens at the Polling Booth

1. Locate your assigned polling booth using your e-EPIC or the ECI's voter helpline app
2. Have your identity verified and your finger marked with indelible ink
3. Sign/thumbprint the register as your name is crossed off the roll
4. Cast your vote on the EVM by pressing the button next to your choice
5. Confirm your vote via the brief VVPAT slip display before leaving the booth

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Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely reported, non-partisan public facts, described for educational awareness.)

- **National Voters' Day:** Celebrated every 25 January to mark the ECI's 1950 founding, encouraging especially newly eligible young voters to register and participate.
- **EVM-VVPAT Supreme Court Ruling (April 2024):** During the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the Supreme Court upheld the existing EVM-VVPAT system, rejecting calls for 100% slip verification or a return to paper ballots, while directing additional technical safeguards.
- **India Chairing International IDEA (2026):** The ECI's global standing was recognised when India assumed the chairmanship of the Council of Member States of International IDEA, an inter-governmental body promoting democracy worldwide, for the year 2026.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: You've just turned 18 and want to vote in the next election.
Register using Form 6 on voters.eci.gov.in well before the electoral roll finalisation deadline for your constituency.

Scenario 2: You moved to a new city and your voter registration is still at your old address.
Apply for a new registration (Form 6) in your current constituency, which will also handle deletion from your previous one.

Scenario 3: After voting, you're unsure whether your EVM selection matched the VVPAT slip shown.
Raise this immediately with the presiding officer at the booth, as prescribed procedures exist for such concerns.

Scenario 4: You receive an unverified message on social media claiming false information about polling dates or candidates.
Verify independently via the official ECI website or app rather than sharing or trusting unofficial sources.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **Election Commission of India (ECI):** The apex constitutional authority conducting and regulating elections nationwide.
- **Chief Electoral Officers (CEOs):** State-level officers implementing ECI directions and managing state electoral rolls.
- **Booth Level Officers (BLOs):** Local officials handling ground-level voter registration and roll verification.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
Article 324, Constitution of India	Establishes the Election Commission of India and its powers
Representation of the People Act, 1950	Governs preparation of electoral rolls
Representation of the People Act, 1951	Governs the actual conduct of elections
Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023	Governs the appointment, service conditions, and term of the CEC and Election Commissioners
Model Code of Conduct	ECI guidelines on conduct during the election period (not a standalone statute, but enforced administratively)

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
ECI established	25 January 1950
Registered voters in India	Over 900 million (90+ crore)
States and Union Territories covered	28 states, 8 Union Territories
Personnel deployed during Lok Sabha elections	Over 1 million
VVPAT machines subject to random cross-verification	5 per assembly constituency/segment
Current CEC	Gyanesh Kumar (26th CEC, in office since 19 February 2025)

(Figures are approximate and current as of 2025–2026; office-holder details are subject to change and should be verified on the ECI's official website.)

Best Practices

- Register or update your voter details well ahead of any upcoming election
- Verify your polling booth location in advance via official ECI tools
- Rely only on the ECI's official website/app for election dates, rules, and results
- Report any bribery, intimidation, or MCC violation you witness to election authorities
- Encourage first-time voters in your family to register as soon as they turn 18

Common Mistakes

- Assuming voter registration is automatic upon turning 18
- Not updating address details after moving to a new constituency
- Ignoring BLO verification requests, delaying registration approval
- Sharing or believing unverified election information from social media
- Not checking polling booth details in advance, causing last-minute confusion

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Turning 18 automatically registers you to vote"	Voter registration requires an active application via Form 6
"EVMs have never been legally reviewed"	The Supreme Court has reviewed and upheld the EVM-VVPAT system multiple times, including in April 2024
"You must tell others who you voted for if asked"	The secrecy of the ballot is a core principle — you are never obligated to disclose your vote
"The Model Code of Conduct is a formal law with court-imposed penalties"	It is a set of ECI-enforced guidelines, administratively binding on parties and candidates during the election period
"Moving cities means losing your right to vote until the next full revision"	You can register at your new address via Form 6 relatively promptly, rather than waiting indefinitely

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Register or update your details via official ECI channels	Don't assume registration happens automatically
Verify your polling booth in advance	Don't wait until election day to check your voting details
Vote free of any inducement or coercion	Don't accept money, gifts, or threats in exchange for your vote
Verify election information only via official ECI sources	Don't trust or forward unverified political claims on social media
Report MCC violations or election malpractice you witness	Don't ignore or normalise such violations

Safety Tips

For Registration & Voting

- Use only the official voters.eci.gov.in portal or ECI-verified apps for registration
- Keep your e-EPIC and reference numbers safe until your registration is confirmed

For Avoiding Misinformation

- Verify election dates, rules, and results only through the ECI's official website
- Be cautious of forwarded messages making unverified claims about the voting process or EVMs

For Reporting Issues

- Report any bribery, coercion, or MCC violation to the Election Commission or local election authorities
- Raise any EVM/VVPAT mismatch concern immediately with the presiding officer at your booth

Practical Checklist

- ☐ Registered as a voter (or confirmed my existing registration is accurate)
- ☐ Verified my current address matches my electoral roll entry
- ☐ Downloaded my e-EPIC
- ☐ Know how to check my assigned polling booth
- ☐ Understand the step-by-step voting process at the booth
- ☐ Know to verify election information only via official ECI sources

Quick Revision Notes

- ECI is a constitutional body (Article 324), established 1950, comprising a CEC and two Election Commissioners
- Form 6 registers new voters; Form 7 objects/deletes; Form 8 corrects existing entries
- Voting involves ID verification, indelible ink marking, EVM button press, and VVPAT slip confirmation
- The Model Code of Conduct applies from election schedule announcement until the process concludes
- The Supreme Court has upheld the EVM-VVPAT system multiple times, including in April 2024
- Ethical voting means voting freely, respecting ballot secrecy, and verifying information officially

Key Takeaways

1. Voter registration is an active step you must take — it is not automatic
2. Accurate electoral roll details are essential to actually being able to vote
3. The voting process follows a consistent, verifiable sequence at every booth nationwide
4. India's EVM-VVPAT system has been reviewed and upheld by the Supreme Court multiple times
5. Ethical, informed voting — free of coercion and misinformation — strengthens democracy itself

Glossary

- **BLO** — Booth Level Officer
- **CEC** — Chief Election Commissioner
- **ECI** — Election Commission of India
- **e-EPIC** — Digital Electors Photo Identity Card
- **EVM** — Electronic Voting Machine
- **MCC** — Model Code of Conduct
- **VVPAT** — Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the Election Commission of India?
An independent constitutional body established under Article 324, responsible for conducting free and fair elections in India.

2. When was the ECI established?
25 January 1950, a date now celebrated annually as National Voters' Day.

3. How do I register as a voter?
By submitting Form 6 online at voters.eci.gov.in.

4. What is the minimum voting age in India?
18 years.

5. What is an e-EPIC?
The digital version of the Electors Photo Identity Card, downloadable after successful registration.

6. What is the electoral roll?
The official list of all registered voters in a constituency.

7. Which form do I use to correct my voter details?
Form 8, for corrections within the same constituency.

8. What is a Booth Level Officer (BLO)?
A local official who verifies voter registration details on the ground.

9. What is the Model Code of Conduct?
ECI guidelines governing the conduct of political parties and candidates during the election period.

10. When does the Model Code of Conduct come into force?
Immediately upon the announcement of the election schedule.

11. What is a VVPAT?
A Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail, an attached unit that briefly displays a paper slip confirming an EVM vote.

12. Has the Supreme Court reviewed the EVM system?
Yes, multiple times, including a significant ruling in April 2024 upholding the existing EVM-VVPAT system.

13. How many EVMs are cross-verified with VVPAT slips per constituency?
5 EVMs per assembly constituency or assembly segment, following Supreme Court directions.

14. What should I do if I believe my VVPAT slip didn't match my vote?
Raise it immediately with the presiding officer at the polling booth.

15. Am I required to tell anyone who I voted for?
No — the secrecy of the ballot means you are never obligated to disclose your vote.

16. What happens if I move to a new city?
You should register at your new address via Form 6; this also facilitates removal from your previous constituency's roll.

17. Who appoints the Chief Election Commissioner?
The President of India, on the recommendation of a Selection Committee headed by the Prime Minister.

18. What is the tenure of the Chief Election Commissioner?
6 years, or until age 65, whichever comes first.

19. Can I check my polling booth location in advance?
Yes, through the ECI's official website or voter helpline app.

20. Is accepting money or gifts for voting a certain way acceptable?
No — ethical voting means voting freely, without any inducement, coercion, or bribery.

21. Where should I verify election-related information?
Only through the Election Commission of India's official website or verified app.

22. What should I do if I witness a Model Code of Conduct violation?
Report it to the Election Commission or local election authorities.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **ECI structure diagram (CEC + 2 Election Commissioners)** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Voter registration flowchart (Form 6 → BLO verification → e-EPIC)** → within "Step-by-Step Understanding"
- **Polling booth process visual (ID check → ink → EVM → VVPAT)** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part D"
- **Model Code of Conduct timeline (Schedule announced → Process concludes)** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part E"
- **EVM-VVPAT legal history timeline** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part G"

Official References

- Election Commission of India — official website and structural documentation
- Constitution of India — Article 324
- Representation of the People Act, 1950, and Representation of the People Act, 1951
- Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023
- Supreme Court of India — *Subramanian Swamy v. Election Commission of India*; *N. Chandrababu Naidu v. Union of India*; Association for Democratic Reforms EVM-VVPAT judgment (April 2024)
- Press Information Bureau (PIB), Government of India

Official Government Website Links

- Election Commission of India: **https://www.eci.gov.in**
- National Voters' Service Portal: **https://voters.eci.gov.in**
- ECI Unified Portal: **https://ecinet.eci.gov.in**
- India.gov.in (National Portal): **https://www.india.gov.in**

Conclusion

Elections give every eligible citizen an equal voice in shaping the country's future — but that voice only counts if you're correctly registered, understand the process, and vote freely and ethically. Knowing how the ECI, the electoral roll, the polling process, and the safeguards around EVMs and VVPATs actually work turns voting from a once-in-a-while formality into an informed act of genuine participation.

This is the next step in your Government Services & Citizen Rights journey with JanGyan. Stay informed, stay engaged, and remember: **a democracy is only as strong as the citizens who show up, informed, to shape it.**
